

The One with the List

Learning English through
90s Sitcom Storytelling

Master essential vocabulary,
idioms, and cultural context
by breaking down a classic
television dilemma.



Two Plots, One Episode



Ross's Romantic Dilemma

Option 1 → Option 2

Ross must choose
between his
long-time crush
(**Rachel**)



and his
current
girlfriend
(**Julie**)



Monica's Culinary Disaster

Monica takes a
grueling job
creating recipes
for a synthetic,
horrible-tasting
chocolate
substitute.

Task: Create recipes for
Mockolate (a synthetic,
terrible substitute).

Navigating a Romantic Dilemma

To be torn between (idiom):
Unable to decide between two options. (*"Ross is torn between Rachel and Julie."*)

Dilemma (noun):
A difficult situation forcing a choice between two equally challenging alternatives.

The Girlfriend

The Crush

Pros and Cons (noun):
The advantages and disadvantages of a decision.

To have feelings for (phrase):
To experience romantic attraction toward someone.



State-of-the-Art (in 1995)

- **12 Megabytes of RAM:** (Noun)
Temporary computer memory.
- **500 Megabyte Hard Drive:** (Noun)
Permanent digital storage.
- **28,000 BPS Modem:** (Noun) A device for dial-up internet that makes terrible screeching noises.
- **To print** (verb): To create a physical paper copy of a digital document.



The Infamous List

RACHEL

- Spoiled: Expecting to always get what you want.
- Ditzzy: Silly or scatterbrained.
- Too into her looks: Vain.
- Chubby ankles: A physical insult (cankles).
- Just a waitress: Lacking professional ambition.

JULIE

- We have common ground: Shared interests (Paleontology).
- She's not Rachem: A hilarious typo (typographical error) for "Rachel."



A waitress in a blue denim apron is dropping three white coffee cups from a black tray. The cups are flying through the air, and coffee is splashing everywhere. The word "JUST" is written in large, bold, black letters across the center of the image, with a cracked glass effect over the letter 'J'. In the background, a cafe setting is visible with other patrons seated at tables.

JUST

The Danger of the Word “Just”

What Ross meant (Logic): They lack professional common ground.
He is a scientist; she is in the service industry.

What Rachel heard (Emotion): She is beneath him. It is an example of Lowly Job Mockery—dismissing someone’s worth based on their employment. Adding “just” turns a simple fact into a deeply offensive insult.

The Chain of Blame

Step 1: The Instigator.
Joey says, "Start with the
cons, they're more fun!"
(Takes ZERO responsibility).



Step 2: The Typist.
Chandler types the list
on his fancy new laptop.



Step 3: The Dictator.
Ross actually says the
insulting words.



Step 4: The Scapegoat.
Joey blames Chandler.

To throw someone under
the bus:
To selfishly blame someone
else to save yourself
(Joey to Chandler).

To take the fall:
To accept the punishment
for a group's mistake.

Audacity: Shocking or
disrespectful behavior.

The "Mockolate" Subplot

Ingredient: Mockolate
(A synthetic chocolate substitute).

Result: Disgusting. The FDA
(Food and Drug Administration)
did not approve it.

Side Effects: May cause a
burning sensation.



Comedic Devices: Sarcasm vs. Exaggeration



Sarcasm (Chandler):
Saying the opposite of what is true to mock someone.

Quote: "Two women love me... my wallet's too small for my fifties, and my diamond shoes are too tight!" (Mocking Ross's 'nightmare' dilemma).



Exaggeration (Phoebe):
Making something seem much worse than it actually is.

Quote: "Oh, sweet Lord! This is what evil must taste like!" (Reacting to the Mockolate).

Caught in the Act

To conceal:

Chandler attempts to conceal the screen by pretending he is writing a short story.

To snatch:

Rachel snatches the printed paper from the guys.

To be devastated:

Rachel is devastated by the betrayal of trust.

To confront:

Rachel confronts Ross about the cruel words he wrote.

A Last-Ditch Effort

The Scenario: Ross stands in the pouring rain and dedicates the song "With or Without You" by U2 on the local radio station to apologize.

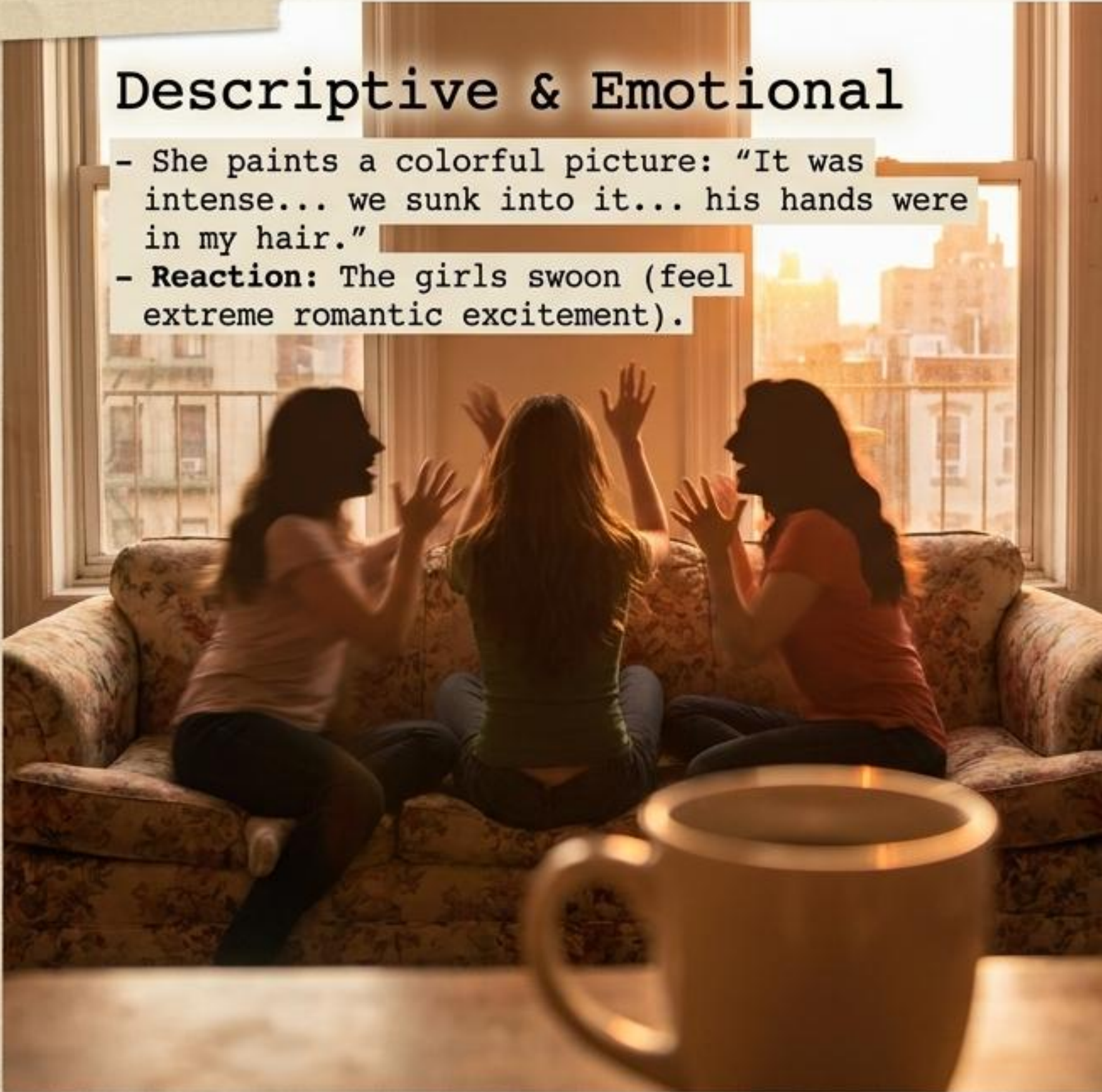
Vocab	Idioms
To make up with: To forgive someone and become friendly again after an argument. A last-ditch effort: A desperate final attempt to fix a problem.	To backfire: When a plan has the opposite of the intended effect (Rachel calls the DJ to complain, and the DJ stops the song on the air).



Mars vs. Venus: Communication Styles

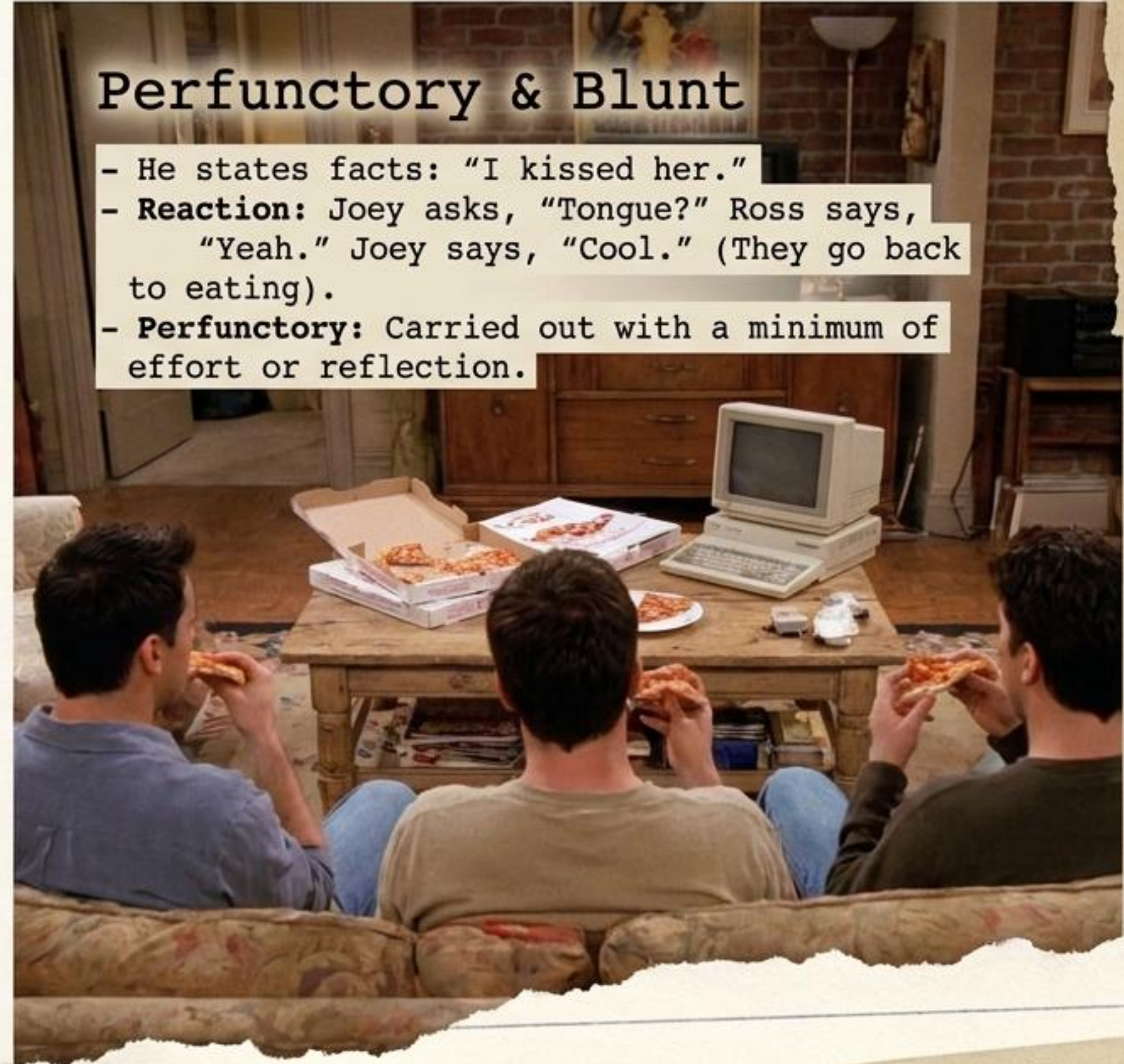
Descriptive & Emotional

- She paints a colorful picture: "It was intense... we sunk into it... his hands were in my hair."
- **Reaction:** The girls swoon (feel extreme romantic excitement).



Perfunctory & Blunt

- He states facts: "I kissed her."
- **Reaction:** Joey asks, "Tongue?" Ross says, "Yeah." Joey says, "Cool." (They go back to eating).
- **Perfunctory:** Carried out with a minimum of effort or reflection.



Comprehension Check

True or False?

1. Ross's list contained many negative personality flaws about Julie.
2. Mockolate is a natural, high-quality baking ingredient.
3. Joey took full responsibility for giving Ross the idea to make the list.
4. Chandler accidentally typed the word "Rachem" instead of "Rachel."
5. The radio DJ successfully helped Ross win Rachel back.



Answers & Discussion

-  1. FALSE (Her only flaw was "She's not Rachel").
-  2. FALSE (It is a synthetic, gross-tasting substitute).
-  3. FALSE (He threw Chandler under the bus).
-  4. TRUE (It was a hilarious typo).
-  5. FALSE (His plan backfired completely).

Notepad Prompt (Your Turn!):

Have you ever made a "pros and cons" list for a major life decision? Did it help you decide, or did it backfire?

Write a short paragraph using at least three vocabulary words from this lesson!